

Corporations pick up tabs for parties at convention

BY TIM FUNK

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Democrats this year pride themselves on the fact that – for the first time ever – not a dime in corporate cash will help pay for their party convention in Charlotte.

But all the parties welcoming delegates and journalists to town? That's a different story – and a different pot of money.

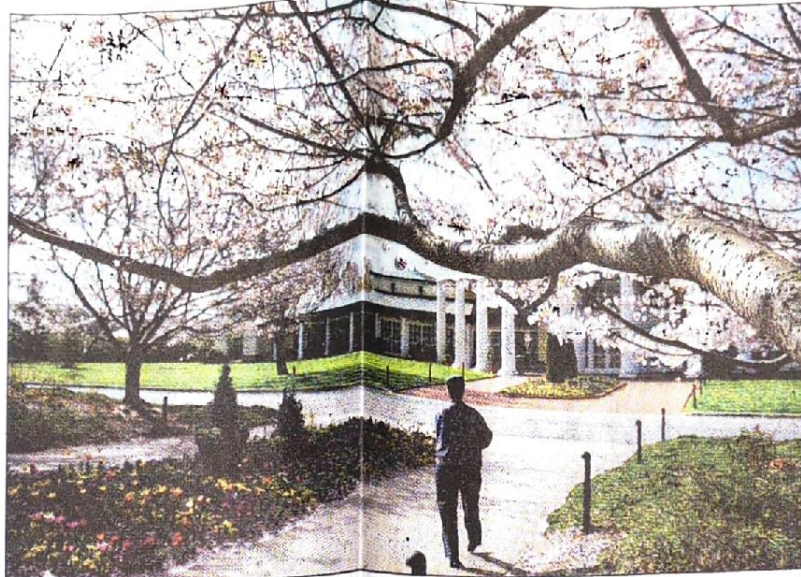
Cash contributions from Duke Energy, Wells Fargo Bank, Belk Stores and others will help pay for the 12 delegate parties announced Tuesday by the Charlotte host committee.

These local businesses have all donated to the "New American City Fund." It's a pot that was estimated – in Observer stories last year – to total about \$15 million. It's being used by Charlotte In 2012 – the host committee's official name – to pay for "the promotion of the city of Charlotte," said spokeswoman Suzi Emmerling.

That covers everything from delegate and press parties to mini-films advertising Charlotte's charms that are sent to national reporters as well as Twitter and Facebook followers. The fund also will pay for the big kick-off party on Labor Day at Charlotte Motor Speedway.

When Charlotte was chosen as the 2012 convention site, the host committee also committed to raising \$36.6 million and turning that money over to the Democratic National Convention Committee. That fund will pay for everything associated with the nominating process inside Time Warner Cable Arena and President Barack Obama's speech at Bank of American Stadium.

At the president's direction, the host committee's contract with the DNCC said that none of that \$36.6 million could be corporate money. Cash from labor union treasuries are accepted, as are in-kind contributions from corporations. DNCC staffers, for example, were given office space owned by Duke Energy.



JOHN D. SIMMONS - 2011 CHARLOTTE OBSERVER FILE PHOTO

DANIEL STOWE BOTANICAL GARDEN Missouri, Arkansas, Kansas and West Virginia

DNC DELEGATE PARTIES

■ from 1A

the District of Columbia and Puerto Rico.

That Discovery Place deal was worth a scream when Charlotte planner Sally Webb of The Special Event Co. got the call several weeks ago.

A very loud scream, Webb admitted before the official announcement Tuesday: "We got our No. 1 pick."

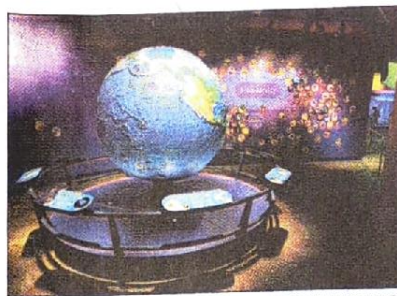
Event planners have been waiting since early February, when they were first given the details on how to make a pitch for one of the parties, which will be used to welcome delegates when they arrive on the Sunday night before the convention.

Up to 200 planners made pitches and only 12 were chosen – actually 13, because two companies teamed up for the big party at the Mint.

The Charlotte in 2012 Host Committee announced in February that the delegates would be spread around 12 spots for the welcoming night, some in uptown and some sprinkled around the region, such as the Daniel Stowe Botanical Garden in Gaston County and the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville.

That will allow the delegates to see more of the area, but it also lets the host committee spread the wealth a little, getting more event planners, caterers, florists, photographers and other party-makers a crack at business. All the planners picked were listed in the committee's vendor directory.

When 12 of the event planners lined up to introduce themselves Tuesday, one thing stood out, though: They were all women. That was a little misleading – only nine of the chosen 13 firms are women-owned companies (four are minority-



DAVID T. FOSTER III - 2010 OBSERVER FILE PHOTO

DISCOVERY PLACE

Texas, New York, Michigan, Minnesota, South Dakota, North Dakota, Louisiana, District of Columbia and Puerto Rico

owned, and at least two are owned or co-owned by men who weren't present).

But Mary Tribble, a longtime Charlotte event planner who is chief of all the events planning for the host committee, admitted she was surprised when she saw them all lined up before the announcement.

"I didn't realize until I walked in and said, 'Wow, look at all these strong women.' That's nothing to apologize for."

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IN LOCAL & STATE

Cybersummit at Johnson C. Smith to coincide with Democratic convention. 3B

Who, what and where?

Dan Murray, executive director of the Charlotte in 2012 Host Committee, said delegations were matched with spaces based on size, type of venue and historic alignments. We'll leave it to you to debate why which states landed where.

BECHTLER MUSEUM OF MODERN ART

DELEGATIONS: Kentucky, U.S. Virgin Islands, abroad, Oklahoma, Indiana.

PLANNER: Jennifer Wouters, Soiree Charlotte.

CAROLINA RAPTOR CENTER

DELEGATIONS: Wisconsin, Nebraska, Iowa.

PLANNER: Kymberly Brantigan, Charlotte Destination Group.

DANIEL STOWE BOTANICAL GARDEN

DELEGATIONS: Missouri, Arkansas, Kansas, West Virginia.

PLANNER: Dina Berg Blazek, Dina Berg Blazek Events.

DISCOVERY PLACE

DELEGATIONS: Texas, New York, Michigan, Minnesota, South Dakota, North Dakota, Louisiana, District of Columbia, Puerto Rico.

PLANNER: Sally Webb, The Special Event Co.

DUKE MANSION

DELEGATIONS: Nevada, Utah, New Mexico, Guam, American Samoa, Wyoming.

PLANNER: April Ellerbe, New Century Planning.

HARVEY B. GANTT CENTER FOR AFRICAN-AMERICAN ARTS + CULTURE

DELEGATIONS: New Hampshire, Maine, Vermont, Massachusetts, Rhode Island, Connecticut.

PLANNER: Karen Lawrence, It's My Affair.

HISTORIC ROSEDALE PLANTATION

DELEGATIONS: Florida, Mississippi, Alabama.

PLANNER: Rhonda Caldwell, The Main Event.

LEVINE MUSEUM OF THE NEW SOUTH

DELEGATIONS: Colorado, Arizona, Washington state, Oregon.

PLANNER: Beth Redlich Mattos, Creative Events.

MINT MUSEUM UPTOWN

DELEGATIONS: Illinois, Delaware, Hawaii, Pennsylvania, Ohio.

PLANNER: Michael Pazyniak, Lighthouse Creative Works, and Anne Markey, Favor Me Events.

NASCAR HALL OF FAME

DELEGATIONS: North Carolina, South Carolina, Virginia, Georgia, Tennessee.

PLANNER: Emily Morrow and Neil Howard, Team Epic.

U.S. NATIONAL WHITEWATER CENTER

DELEGATIONS: California, Alaska, Idaho, Montana.

PLANNER: Carrie McCament, GO! Productions.

WADSWORTH ESTATE

DELEGATIONS: New Jersey, Maryland

PLANNER: Aisha Thomas, Event Fantasies.